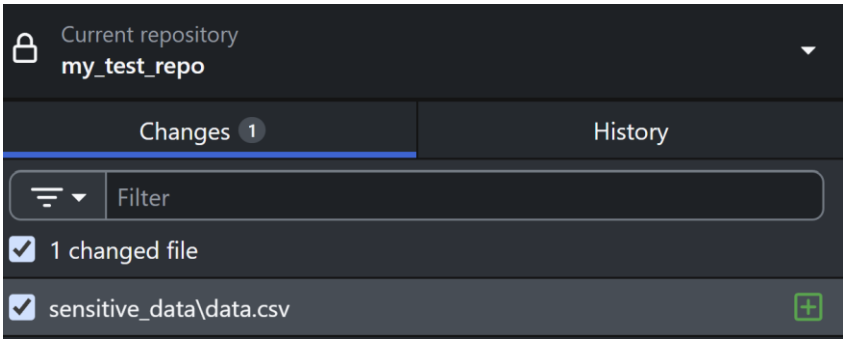
Supplementary material: keep sensitive data out of Git with .gitignore

Some files should never end up on GitHub: personal or confidential data, large datasets, passwords, or temporary files. The `.gitignore` file tells Git which files and folders to ignore. This exercise uses your `my_test_repo` repository.

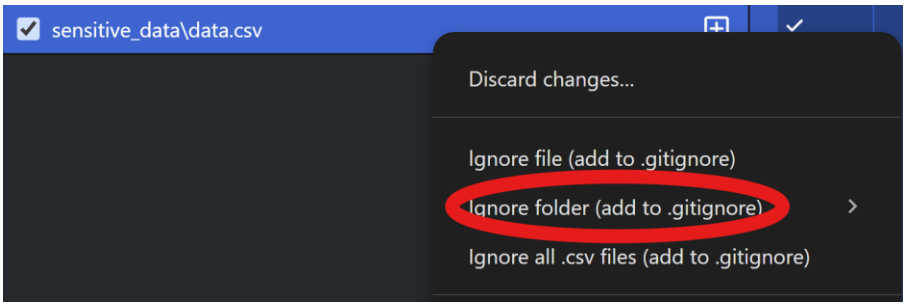
Step 1. Add a folder with “sensitive” data

- Open your `my_test_repo` folder: right-click on “Current repository” in GitHub Desktop and click “Show in Explorer”/“Show in Finder”
- Create a new folder called `sensitive_data`
- Copy `data.csv` into this new folder
- Go back to GitHub Desktop: `sensitive_data/data.csv` appears in the “Changes” tab. **Do not commit it.**

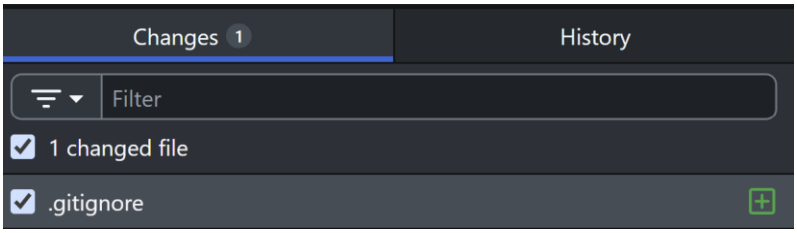


Step 2. How to ignore the folder

- In the “Changes” tab, right-click on `sensitive_data/data.csv`
- Click “Ignore folder (Add sensitive_data/ to .gitignore)”



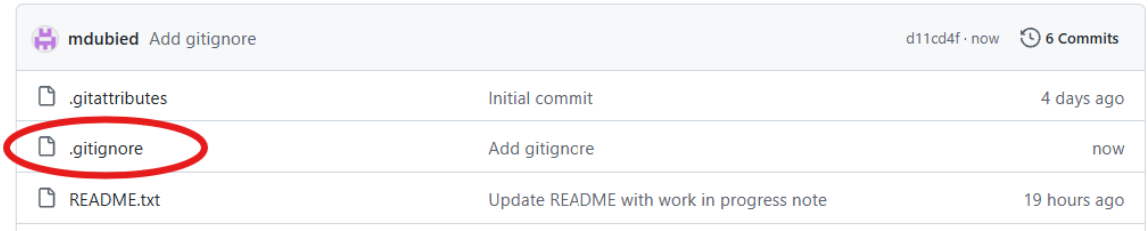
- `sensitive_data/data.csv` disappears from the “Changes” tab. Instead, a new file appears: `.gitignore`, with the line `sensitive_data/`



The folder "sensitive_data" is still in your folder on your computer. Git simply does not track it anymore, so it can never be committed or pushed by mistake. It won't end up online and GitHub won't have access to it.

Step 3. Commit and push the .gitignore file

- Write a summary (e.g., “Ignore sensitive data”) and click “Commit to main”
- Click “Push origin”
- Open your repository on GitHub web: `.gitignore` is there, but the `sensitive_data` folder is not



The `.gitignore` file itself should be committed, so the same rules apply on every computer and for every collaborator.

Step 4. Edit the .gitignore file yourself (optional)

`.gitignore` is a simple text file: one rule per line. You can open it with a text editor (in GitHub Desktop: Repository --> Repository settings... --> Ignored files, or the “Git ignore” tab).

Some useful rules:

- `sensitive_data/` ignores a whole folder
- `*.csv` ignores all files ending with .csv
- `something_to_not_track.csv` ignores a specific file (here a hypothetical file called `something_to_not_track.csv`)

Note: Files starting with a dot are hidden by default. To see `.gitignore` in your folder, press Cmd+Shift+. in Finder (Mac), or tick View --> Show --> Hidden items in File Explorer (Windows).

`.gitignore` only works for files that have never been committed. If you have already committed sensitive data, adding it to `.gitignore` will not remove it.